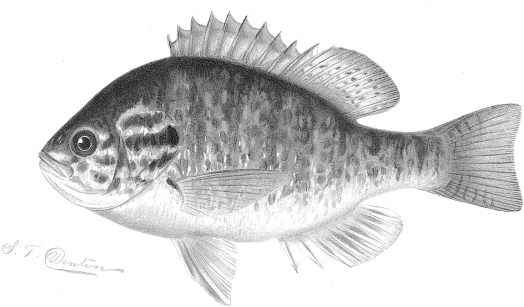


Pumpkinseed

The other sunfish on the bed

Lepomis gibbosus



Sunfish (*Eupomotis gibbosus*) — chromolithograph by S. F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Tell it apart	An orange-red spot on the trailing edge of the black ear flap, and wavy pale-blue lines radiating back across the cheek and gill cover. The fins are speckled. There is <i>no</i> dark blotch at the back of the soft dorsal — that blotch belongs to the bluegill.
Shape	Rounder and deeper-bodied than a bluegill, with a slightly larger mouth and shorter, more rounded pectoral fins.
Size here	5–7 in. Rarely as large as a good bluegill, and usually a smaller share of the catch.
Spawn	Same window as bluegill, 65–70 °F, often on the same colonial beds — and the two species hybridize, which is why you will occasionally land something that fits neither description.
Eats	Snails above all — it has crushing teeth in its throat for them — plus insect larvae and small crustaceans.
Season	

Where and how

Habitat	Shallower and weedier than bluegill, and more tied to cover. Pine spots 6 and 1 ; North spots 1 and 7 .
Depth	1–8 ft, in and against vegetation. If you are catching bluegill on the deep weed edge and pumpkinseed on the inside edge, that is normal.
Rig	Identical to bluegill — slip bobber, split shot, size 8 or 10 hook, small piece of worm. <i>see the slip bobber sheet</i>
Counts as	Panfish, under the 25 per day aggregate limit.

Worth knowing on the bed

When you find a June sunfish colony you will usually be catching both species plus the occasional hybrid. Sorting them on the spot is a good five-minute lesson for a child: flip the gill cover into the light and look for the orange dot.

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